

The gods were always listening, and Athena heard Arachne's words. The goddess appeared in an instant. "You have challenged me, mortal," Athena said, "and I accept that challenge." She went straight to the loom next to Arachne, and they both immediately went to work.

*The rival weavers soon completed their projects and laid them out for one another to see.*

Athena had woven scenes of mortals who gloated to the gods and the punishments they received for doing so. Her golden thread shone as it showed Antigone, who was changed into a stork when she said she had more beautiful hair than Hera's, and many more mortals like her.

Arachne's tapestry, meanwhile, included acts of cruelty committed by the gods on mortals, such as Zeus transforming into a bull and stealing Europa away from her home. Arachne wanted to show that the gods weren't perfect.

*Unfortunately, Arachne had forgotten that she could never outdo a goddess.*

Furious, Athena tore Arachne's work to shreds, then cast a spell upon the girl. First, all of Arachne's long hair fell out, and then her body shrank. New legs sprang from her sides until she had eight instead of two. Athena had transformed Arachne into a spider, cursed to weave webs forever.

